

Bharatanatyam

A neutral, balanced survey of history, scholarship, and the ongoing debates surrounding South India's classical dance

Prepared for research, debate preparation & academic discussion · Tip: every section has a purple “My points” box — type in it and your notes save automatically in this browser.

FACT

Well supported by texts, inscriptions, or documented record.

INTERPRETATION

A reasonable scholarly reading that remains contested.

CONTROVERSY

An active dispute where credible scholars/communities disagree.

1

Introduction to Bharatanatyam

Definition

Bharatanatyam is a solo classical dance form from southern India, historically centred in the Tamil-speaking region (present-day Tamil Nadu). It integrates three elements named in Sanskrit/Tamil poetics: *nritta* (pure rhythmic dance), *nritya* (expressive, interpretive dance), and *natya* (dramatic enactment). Its expressive language rests on *abhinaya* — the art of communicating emotion — especially *hasta mudras* (codified hand gestures), facial expression, and *bhava-rasa* aesthetics (the evocation of emotional “flavour”).

The name

FACT The term *Bharatanatyam* came into wide use only in the **20th century**. Earlier, the temple-and-court repertoire was called **sadir** (or *sadir kacheri*), **dasiattam** (“dance of the dasis”), or **chinna melam**. Whether “Bharata” honours the sage **Bharata Muni** (author of the *Natyashastra*) or is a folk acronym for *bha(va)–ra(ga)–ta(la)* is debated; scholars generally treat the acronym as a later popular gloss, not an etymology.

Significance & why it is “classical”

FACT India's Sangeet Natak Akademi recognizes Bharatanatyam as one of the country's principal classical dances (with Kathak, Kathakali, Kuchipudi, Odissi, Manipuri, Mohiniyattam, and Sattriya). The “classical” label rests on a codified grammar traceable to Sanskrit treatises and Tamil performance lineages; a structured concert sequence (the *margam*); a continuous teachable pedagogy (the *guru–shishya* and *nattuvanar* traditions); and a developed theory of aesthetics.

INTERPRETATION

Critics note that “classical” status was itself partly a 20th-century construction shaped by nationalist cultural politics as much as by intrinsic antiquity (Allen; Meduri).

Place in Tamil & Indian culture

FACT The dance is embedded in Tamil temple, court, and literary culture, and its core lyrical repertoire is largely in Tamil, Telugu, Sanskrit, and Kannada. **INTERPRETATION** It is simultaneously claimed as a *Tamil* regional heritage and a pan-*Indian* national emblem — a dual identity that recurs throughout the debates below.

MY POINTS — §1

Add your own notes, questions, or debate points here...

2 Origins & Early History

Deep antiquity in the Tamil region

FACT Dance and music are attested in Tamil culture from the **Sangam era** (roughly 300 BCE–300 CE). The later Tamil epic *Cilappatikaram* (*Silappadikaram*, c. 5th–6th century CE by traditional dating) describes a dancer, **Madhavi**, and references a structured performance culture. **INTERPRETATION** How directly that ancient practice connects to the modern *margam* is uncertain; continuity is asserted by tradition but cannot be demonstrated step-by-step from the record.

The Natyashastra

FACT The *Natyashastra*, attributed to **Bharata Muni** and generally dated c. 200 BCE–200 CE, is the foundational Sanskrit treatise on drama, dance, and music for the whole subcontinent, codifying *rasa* theory,

bhava, *karanas* (movement units), and *angika abhinaya*.

INTERPRETATION

The *Natyashastra* is a **pan-Indian** text, not specifically a Tamil or Bharatanatyam manual; later teachers mapped its categories onto South Indian practice. In daily pedagogy the medieval *Abhinaya Darpana* of **Nandikeshvara** is more directly used for hand-gesture vocabulary.

Temple traditions & inscriptions

FACT Inscriptions document women dedicated to temple service from at least the medieval period. Under the **Chola dynasty** (9th–13th c.) — notably at the **Brihadisvara (Rajarajeshvara) temple, Thanjavur**, consecrated c. 1010 CE by Rajaraja I — records describe the appointment of many temple women (*devaradiyar*) with assigned roles and shares of temple resources. **INTERPRETATION** How closely their dance resembled later *sadir* is inferred, not documented choreographically.

Codification of the modern repertoire

FACT — A SECURE ANCHOR

The structured solo sequence performed today (the *margam*) was substantially shaped in the **early 19th century** at the **Thanjavur (Tanjore) court** by the **Tanjore Quartet** — brothers **Chinnayya, Ponnayya, Sivanandam, and Vadivelu** — under Maratha king **Serfoji II** (and later Mysore). They arranged the classic order: *alarippu* → *jatiswaram* → *shabdham* → *varnam* → *padams/javalis* → *tillana* → *mangalam*. This anchor is comparatively recent — about 200 years old.

The form as a layered tradition: ancient pan-Indian theory (*Natyashastra*) + Tamil performance & literary culture + medieval temple institutions + 19th-century court codification + 20th-century revival and stage reform.

MY POINTS — §2

Add your own notes...



Ancient Tamil Music & Folk-Dance Roots

Bharatanatyam's classical grammar sits atop a much older and broader Tamil performance culture of music and folk dance. This section sketches that substratum — the instruments, social dances, and ritual contexts from which a wider Tamil dance heritage grew.

The Yaazh — the ancient Tamil harp

FACT The **Yaazh** (yāl), a harp-like string instrument, is among the earliest documented Tamil musical instruments. It features prominently in Sangam-era literature and art and is widely regarded as the first musical instrument attested in Tamil sources.

FACT The epic *Silappatikaram* enumerates four types of Yaazh, distinguished by the number of strings (counts as given in the epic and its traditional commentaries):

- **Peri Yaazh** — 21 to 29 strings
- **Makara Yaazh** — 19 strings
- **Cakota (Sakoda) Yaazh** — 14 strings
- **Cenkotti Yaazh** — 7 strings

FACT The *Thirukkural*, by the poet-philosopher **Thiruvalluvar**, also references the instrument.

INTERPRETATION

The Yaazh later receded in favour of the veena; because no instrument survives intact, modern reconstructions of its tuning and playing technique are conjectural and debated.

Social origins of Tamil folk dance

FACT Tamil folk dances — such as **Kummi**, **Kolattam**, **Karagattam**, and **Devarattam** — originated in village gatherings, harvest celebrations (notably *Pongal*), weddings, initiations, and other life-cycle milestones.

- They are performed not for entertainment alone but to express joy, strengthen social bonds, and mark transitions in village and family life.
- Community members participate regardless of formal training; the dances are frequently improvisational and spontaneous at social functions.

INTERPRETATION — A COMPARATIVE NOTE

In contrast to dance traditions in some other cultures that emerged primarily as vehicles of *individual* or *political* self-expression and resistance, Tamil social dance developed chiefly as a **collective, ritual, and celebratory** expression — rooted in community festivals, worship, and life-cycle events, and emphasizing belonging and shared identity rather than resistance. (Offered as a framing/comparison, not a value judgement on either tradition.)

Ritual and identity

FACT Several dances carry explicit ritual purpose: **Karagattam** is performed to invoke the rain goddess **Mariamman**, and **Kavadi Attam** is performed in devotion to **Lord Murugan**. These express communal petitions, gratitude, and devotion, tying dance to Tamil religious identity.

INTERPRETATION Such dances also served to maintain and transmit folklore, mythology, and community values across generations — functioning as a medium of cultural memory and storytelling.

Dance as social gathering & evolving traditions

- **FACT** These dances continue to bring communities together at festivals, weddings, and auspicious occasions, encouraging collective participation and reinforcing cultural identity.
- **INTERPRETATION** With modernization, Tamil folk dances have adapted — absorbing new styles, staging, and media — yet retain their core role in socialization, devotion, and celebration, keeping the traditions alive.

INTERPRETATION — RELATION TO BHARATANATYAM

This folk and devotional substratum (the *desi* / popular stream) is distinct from the classical solo *margam* of the temple-and-court lineage (the *margi* / codified stream), but both draw on the same broad Tamil cultural matrix. The dancer-scholar **Padma Subrahmanyam** is notable here for reconstructing the 108 *karanas* of the *Natyashastra* from temple sculpture — an example of how classical and older Tamil sources are read together in modern scholarship.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING (ADDED BY REQUEST)

- [Padma Subrahmanyam — Wikipedia](#) (dancer-scholar; *karana* reconstruction)
- [History of Bharatanatyam — Samyukta](#)
- [Music and Dance of Tamil Nadu — Maps of India](#)
- [eAmbalam — Samaagama](#) (arts knowledge portal).
- [“Caste Conflicts & Carnatic Music” — Maddy's Ramblings](#) (blog).

Note on reliability: Wikipedia is a tertiary source useful for orientation and onward citations; Maps of India and eAmbalam are general/educational references; the blog entry is a personal-blog essay. For academic use, verify their underlying claims against the scholarly sources listed in Appendix C.

MY POINTS — TAMIL MUSIC & FOLK ROOTS

Add your own notes...

3

The Devadasi Tradition

Who they were

FACT *Devadasi* (“female servant of the deity”; Tamil *devaradiyar*, *tevaratiyar*) refers to women ritually dedicated to a temple deity. The institution had regional variants (e.g., *maharis* in Odisha, *joginis* elsewhere). In the Tamil region these women, with the male **nattuvanars** (dance masters/conductors), were the principal hereditary practitioners of *sadir*/Bharatanatyam.

Roles in temple & society

FACT Documented roles: performing ritual dance and music in temple ceremonies and processions; tending temple lamps and services; and participating in court and elite patronage. Many held a distinctive status — they could own and inherit property (unusual for women of the era), were trained and literate in music and dance, and were regarded as *nitya sumangali* (“ever-auspicious”). The dance lineage passed through their families and associated nattuvanars.

Contribution to preservation

INTERPRETATION — WIDELY ACCEPTED

Devadasi families and nattuvanars were the **custodians of the living repertoire, technique, and music** through the 18th–19th centuries. Without them there would have been no codified art for the 20th century to inherit (Srinivasan; Soneji; Kersenboom).

The central historical debate

CONTROVERSY

Interpretations of devadasi status diverge sharply:

- **Exploitation view** (colonial reformers & some social reformers): the system entailed concubinage, hereditary obligation, and sexual availability to patrons — effectively institutionalized exploitation.
- **Revisionist view** (Amrit Srinivasan 1985; Kersenboom; Soneji): the colonial framing flattened a complex institution; devadasis had unusual autonomy, economic independence, artistic prestige, and ritual authority — and reform *dispossessed* them of their hereditary profession.
- **Balanced reading**: both can be partly true — genuine prestige and rare female autonomy *and*, by the 19th–20th centuries, economic precarity, hereditary compulsion, and sexual exploitation in many cases, varying by region, temple, period, and family.

FACT Not in dispute: the institution was hereditary, gendered, and tied to temple economies, and it was the matrix from which modern Bharatanatyam emerged.

MY POINTS — §3

Add your own notes...

4 Transformation During Colonial Rule

FACT **British attitudes.** Colonial and missionary discourse generally viewed temple dance through a Victorian moral lens, labelling performers “nautch girls” and associating the practice with prostitution — a framing both moralistic and useful to colonial critiques of Hindu society.

FACT **The Anti-Nautch movement.** From the **1890s**, a coalition of British officials, Christian missionaries, and Indian social reformers campaigned against dedicating girls to temples and against dance at social functions, circulating pledges asking elites not to invite “nautch” performances.

FACT **Indian reformers & legislation.** The campaign was carried by Indian reformers, above all **Dr. Muthulakshmi Reddy** — born into a devadasi-associated family, a pioneering physician and legislator — who pressed abolition through the Madras Legislative Council. This culminated in the **Madras Devadasis (Prevention of Dedication) Act, 1947** (preceded by measures in the 1920s–30s), abolishing temple dedication in the Madras Presidency.

CONTROVERSY — DOUBLE-EDGED EFFECT

Reform ended a system many considered exploitative — yet it simultaneously **delegitimized the hereditary profession**, often pushing devadasis and nattuvanars into poverty and stigma, even as the art they preserved was, in the same decades, “rescued” and re-presented by others. Whether this was liberation, dispossession, or both is among the field's most contested questions (Soneji, *Unfinished Gestures*, 2012; Srinivasan).

MY POINTS — §4

Add your own notes...

5

Revival of Bharatanatyam in the 20th Century

FACT **Context.** In the 1920s–40s, as the hereditary system was abolished, a parallel “revival” repositioned the dance as a respectable national art for the urban middle class — coinciding with nationalism's search for indigenous cultural symbols.

Key figures

- **E. Krishna Iyer** (1897–1968) — **FACT** lawyer, Carnatic musician, and freedom-movement figure who publicly defended sadir against abolitionists, organized performances (via the Madras Music Academy, founded 1928), and is credited with promoting the name “Bharatanatyam.”
- **Rukmini Devi Arundale** (1904–1986) — **FACT** a Brahmin woman and Theosophist who learned from nattuvanar **Pandanallur Meenakshisundaram Pillai** and founded **Kalakshetra** (Chennai, 1936), institutionalizing training. **INTERPRETATION** celebrated for elevating the form's status and building an enduring institution — and criticized for “de-eroticizing” the repertoire and distancing the art from its devadasi originators.
- **T. Balasaraswati** (1918–1984) — **FACT** renowned performer from a hereditary devadasi/nattuvanar lineage (family of Veena Dhanammal); represented **continuity**, defended the *sringara* content of *padam*

and *javali*, and resisted wholesale “purification.”

- **The nattuvanars** — **FACT** especially the **Pandanallur** lineage and descendants of the Tanjore Quartet — were the indispensable teachers who transmitted technique to the new generation. Later exponents include Mrinalini Sarabhai, Yamini Krishnamurthy, and many Kalakshetra graduates.

INTERPRETATION

Balasaraswati and Rukmini Devi are often read as two poles of the revival: **hereditary continuity** vs. **reformist reconstruction**.

Institutionalization & changes in presentation

FACT Kalakshetra (1936), the Music Academy's programming, and later state bodies (Sangeet Natak Akademi, est. 1952) moved training from hereditary families to schools with formal syllabi, certification, and the public *arangetram* debut. The revival also altered:

- **Venue** — temple/salon → proscenium stage and concert hall.
- **Costume** — the stitched “pyjama” costume, fan-pleat, and standardized temple jewelry (Kalakshetra style).
- **Repertoire** — shift toward devotional themes; some overtly erotic *javalis/padams* de-emphasized in reformist schools (retained in others); group choreography and dance-dramas introduced.
- **Audience** — ritual/patron communities → ticketed urban publics and the global diaspora.

MY POINTS — \$5

Add your own notes...

6 The Role of Brahmins in Bharatanatyam

One of the most sensitive topics; the competing positions are stated explicitly.

FACT **Historical participation.** The hereditary performers (devadasis) and many nattuvanars were **not** Brahmins; they belonged to specific non-Brahmin communities (often within the *Isai Vellalar* / *Melakkarar* musician communities). Brahmins were historically tied to temple priesthood and Sanskrit/Vedic learning, not to dance as a hereditary profession.

FACT **Brahmin involvement in the revival.** Several leading revival figures were Brahmins — notably **Rukmini Devi Arundale** and **E. Krishna Iyer** — and much of the new middle-class student body came from Brahmin and other upper-caste/upwardly-mobile communities.

INTERPRETATION — THE “PRESERVATION” ARGUMENT

Revivalists **rescued an art under existential threat**: with dedication abolished and the hereditary system collapsing, advocates gave the form legitimacy, institutions, documentation, and a future — broadening access beyond hereditary families.

CONTROVERSY — THE “APPROPRIATION” CRITIQUE

A strong body of scholarship and activism argues the revival **expropriated** the art from the devadasi communities who created and preserved it; that those communities were stigmatized and excluded even as their repertoire was absorbed and “purified”; and that the reframing erased non-Brahmin authorship while crediting upper-caste reformers. The term “*Brahminization*” is used in this literature for the demographic shift and the “Sanskritized”/temple-devotional reframing (Soneji; echoed by Dalit/anti-caste commentators and hereditary-community descendants).

Scholarly perspectives — both sides

- **Value of revival:** it is acknowledged across the literature that the revival created durable institutions and global reach, and that figures like Krishna Iyer genuinely defended the art when it was attacked.
- **Appropriation critique:** Soneji, Srinivasan, and Allen document the social dispossession of hereditary communities and the rewriting of the art's narrative.
- **Synthesis (mainstream consensus):** Matthew Harp Allen (“Rewriting the Script for South Indian Dance,” 1997) and Janet O'Shea treat the revival not as preservation *or* appropriation but as **reconstruction/reinvention** — simultaneous re-population (who dances), re-naming, re-ritualization, re-positioning (temple→stage), and re-storation. The modern art is genuinely rooted in the older tradition *and* substantially transformed, with real losses for the originating communities.

NEUTRAL SUMMARY OF THE DOCUMENTED RECORD

Originators were largely non-Brahmin hereditary communities; prominent revivalists included Brahmins; the practitioner base broadened to upper-caste urban groups; hereditary communities were marginalized in the same period. How to *evaluate* this sequence morally and culturally remains contested.

Add your own notes...

7 Bharatanatyam & Caste

FACT **Historical caste dynamics.** The tradition was sustained by specific communities — devadasi women and nattuvanar/musician communities (often Isai Vellalar). Access was **hereditary and caste-bound**: largely closed to outsiders, while dedication was an expectation within those families.

FACT **Shifts in access.** 20th-century institutionalization **opened formal training** to anyone who could pay and attend a school — broadening access in principle, while in practice the new student base skewed toward upper-caste, economically comfortable urban families. **INTERPRETATION** Access was thus simultaneously democratized (in principle) and re-stratified (in practice, along class/caste lines).

CONTROVERSY — MODERN DISCUSSIONS

- Calls to **credit and re-include hereditary communities** and to teach the art's full social history.
- Critiques that the field remains **dominated by upper-caste practitioners**, with barriers for Dalit and lower-caste dancers.
- High-profile interventions by anti-caste artists — e.g. **Nrithya Pillai**, a dancer from a hereditary nattuvanar lineage, who publicly challenges the “Brahminical” narrative of the revival. These debates are active and unsettled.

Add your own notes...

8 Bharatanatyam & Religion

FACT **Devotional content.** Much of the repertoire is devotional, drawing on Hindu (especially Shaiva and Vaishnava bhakti) themes — Shiva (Nataraja), Vishnu/Krishna, Murugan, Devi — set to composers such as the Tanjore Quartet, Muthuswami Dikshitar, and Kshetrappa. The *margam* historically culminated in devotional address to the deity, and the temple was its original ritual setting.

CONTROVERSY / INTERPRETATION — IS IT INHERENTLY RELIGIOUS?

Three positions coexist:

1. **Inherently devotional:** a spiritual practice and offering (*bhakti*), inseparable from Hindu cosmology and temple ritual.
2. **An art using religious material:** the technique, aesthetics, and theory form an artistic system; religious themes are *content* performable by anyone — much as Western classical music includes sacred works.
3. **Both, by context:** the same item can be devotion for one dancer and aesthetic craft for another.

FACT **Practice across faiths today.** Bharatanatyam is taught and performed by people of many faiths and none, including Muslim and Christian exponents, in secular concert settings worldwide. Some dancers create repertoire on non-Hindu or secular themes (Christian, Sufi, social-justice, environmental, abstract).

CONTROVERSY Some religious-nationalist commentators contest such cross-faith or secular adaptations, while many dancers defend the form's openness — itself part of the religious-identity debate.

MY POINTS — \$8

Add your own notes...

9

Bharatanatyam as Culture

CONTROVERSY — THE CLASSIFICATION QUESTION

Bharatanatyam is variously claimed as:

- **Tamil regional heritage** — its language, lineages, temple base, and the Tanjore court are Tamil.
- **Indian national heritage** — its 20th-century elevation as a “national classical” art, *Natyashastra* roots, and global role as an emblem of “Indian culture.”
- **Hindu religious practice** — its devotional origin and content.
- **A performing/secular art** — its technique, theory, and global concert life.

These are not mutually exclusive; the disagreement is about **emphasis and ownership**, and it carries political weight — Tamil regionalists, Hindu cultural organizations, anti-caste activists, and cosmopolitan artists each foreground a different framing.

Viewpoints

- *Scholars* tend to describe it as a constructed “classical” tradition — historically real but modern in its present form (Allen, Meduri, O'Shea).
- *Many practitioners* experience it as a living devotional and artistic discipline.
- *Hereditary-community voices* foreground its specific caste-and-community origins.

FACT **Contemporary role.** Today the form functions as a performing art; a marker of cultural identity (especially in the Tamil and Indian diaspora); a vehicle of childhood education and the *arangetram* rite of passage; and a medium for social and political commentary.

MY POINTS — \$9

Add your own notes...

10

Evolution of Bharatanatyam

FACT **Traditional vs. modern.** “Traditional” usually denotes the *margam* and *abhinaya* transmitted through hereditary/nattuvanar lineages and the stylistic schools (*banis*) — Kalakshetra, Pandanallur, Vazhuvoor, Thanjavur. “Modern” denotes innovations in theme, staging, group choreography, lighting, recorded music, and cross-disciplinary collaboration.

FACT **Globalization.** Through migration and institutions, Bharatanatyam is now taught and performed across North America, the UK, Southeast Asia, Australia, the Gulf, and beyond; the diaspora *arangetram* is a major institution (Janet O'Shea, *At Home in the World*, 2007).

FACT **Contemporary themes & innovation.** Choreographers address gender, caste, climate, mental health, mythological reinterpretation, abstraction, and inter-art fusion. Figures associated with innovation include **Chandralekha** (radical reworking of form and gender), **Mallika Sarabhai** (social/political themes), and many diaspora artists.

INTERPRETATION — CHALLENGES & FUTURE

Commonly cited: balancing innovation with grammatical integrity; inclusion (caste, gender, male and LGBTQ+ dancers); commercialization of the arangetram “industry”; preserving live music and the nattuvanar role; and digital transmission. The form's vitality is not in doubt; its governance, ownership, and meaning are.

Add your own notes...

11

Major Debates & Controversies

1. **Cultural ownership** — Tamil regional vs. Indian national vs. community-specific (hereditary) claims; who has standing to define, reform, or innovate.
2. **Religious identity** — Hindu devotional practice vs. secular/cross-faith art; tension when non-Hindu performers or secular themes appear, and when religious-nationalist actors assert exclusive Hindu ownership.
3. **Caste representation** — the revival's role in marginalizing originating non-Brahmin/devadasi communities; the present upper-caste skew; demands for recognition and access.
4. **Authenticity vs. modernization** — whether reform “purified” or “distorted” the art; whether innovation enriches or dilutes it; the status of the de-eroticized repertoire.
5. **Inclusion & accessibility** — class barriers (cost of training and arangetrams), gender (a historically female solo form and the place of male dancers), and broadening participation.

CONTROVERSY — NOTE FOR DEBATE

In each debate, credible scholars, practitioners, and community representatives hold opposing, sincerely argued positions. None is resolved by a single fact; they turn on values, emphasis, and contested historical interpretation.

Add your own notes...

WHERE THE EVIDENCE IS FIRM — BROAD AGREEMENT

- Dance has deep roots in Tamil and pan-Indian culture; theory codified in the *Natyashastra*; Tamil performance attested from the Sangam era.
- The modern *margam* was substantially shaped by the **Tanjore Quartet in the early 19th century**.
- The art was preserved into the modern era principally by **non-Brahmin devadasi communities and nattuvanars**.
- A **colonial-era reform/abolition** movement (Anti-Nautch; Madras Act, 1947) ended temple dedication.
- A **20th-century revival** renamed, re-staged, institutionalized, and globalized the form, broadening its practitioner base.
- The revival brought **real gains** (legitimacy, institutions, global reach) *and* **real losses** (dispossession of hereditary communities).

WHERE DEBATE CONTINUES

- Whether the revival is best called **preservation, appropriation, or reconstruction** (consensus leans to “reconstruction,” but moral evaluation differs).
- Whether the form is **essentially religious, cultural, or artistic**, and who **owns** it.
- How to **redress caste exclusion** and re-include hereditary communities.
- How far **modernization** can go while remaining “Bharatanatyam.”

Balanced closing statement. Bharatanatyam is simultaneously ancient and modern: a genuinely old performance culture whose present form was deliberately reconstructed in the 20th century. Honest scholarship credits the hereditary communities who created and preserved it, acknowledges the revivalists who institutionalized and globalized it, and recognizes that this same transformation marginalized the originators. The most defensible position is not to choose one narrative but to hold the documented facts together with their tensions intact.

Add your own notes...

A Appendices & Sources

A — Concise Timeline

Period	Event
c. 200 BCE–200 CE	<i>Natyashastra</i> of Bharata Muni (pan-Indian dramaturgy) — date approximate
c. 300 BCE–300 CE	Sangam-era Tamil dance/music culture; later <i>Cilappatikaram</i> references
c. 1010 CE	Brihadisvara temple (Thanjavur) consecrated; Chola inscriptions on temple women
Medieval	<i>Abhinaya Darpana</i> (Nandikeshvara) — gesture vocabulary
Early 19th c.	Tanjore Quartet codify the <i>margam</i> under Maratha patronage (Serfoji II)
1890s	Anti-Nautch movement begins
1920s–30s	Reform legislation; Muthulakshmi Reddy's campaign
1928	Madras Music Academy founded (platform for revival)
1930s	E. Krishna Iyer's advocacy; “Bharatanatyam” name popularized
1936	Rukmini Devi Arundale founds Kalakshetra
1947	Madras Devadasis (Prevention of Dedication) Act
1952	Sangeet Natak Akademi established
Late 20th c.–present	Globalization, diaspora practice, innovation, caste/ownership debates

B — Key Figures

- **Bharata Muni** — attributed author, *Natyashastra*.
- **Nandikeshvara** — *Abhinaya Darpana*.
- **Tanjore Quartet** (Chinnayya, Ponnayya, Sivanandam, Vadivelu) — codifiers of the *margam*.
- **Muthulakshmi Reddy** — physician-legislator, abolition advocate.
- **E. Krishna Iyer** — revival advocate, renaming.
- **Rukmini Devi Arundale** — Kalakshetra founder, reformer.
- **T. Balasaraswati** — hereditary exponent, defender of *sringara* and continuity.
- **Pandanallur Meenakshisundaram Pillai** — leading nattuvanar/teacher.
- **Chandralekha, Mallika Sarabhai, Nrithya Pillai** — contemporary innovators and critical voices.

C — Suggested Scholarly Sources

- Amrit Srinivasan, “Reform and Revival: The Devadasi and Her Dance,” *Economic and Political Weekly* (1985).
- Matthew Harp Allen, “Rewriting the Script for South Indian Dance,” *TDR/The Drama Review* (1997).
- Daves Soneji, *Unfinished Gestures: Devadasis, Memory, and Modernity in South India* (2012).
- Avanthi Meduri — dissertation and essays on Bharatanatyam's modern construction.
- Janet O'Shea, *At Home in the World: Bharata Natyam on the Global Stage* (2007).
- Saskia Kersenboom-Story, *Nityasumangali: Devadasi Tradition in South India* (1987).
- Hari Krishnan, *Celluloid Classicism: Early Tamil Cinema and the Making of Modern Bharatanatyam* (2019).
- Kapila Vatsyayan & Sunil Kothari — documentary surveys of Indian classical dance.

MY POINTS — APPENDIX / GENERAL

Add references, your own sources, or general notes...

About verification: claims tagged **INTERPRETATION** or **CONTROVERSY** should be checked against the cited primary scholarship before academic use — datings (especially of the *Natyashastra* and *Cilappatikaram*) and evaluative conclusions remain subject to ongoing revision.

Prepared as a balanced research & debate-preparation reference. Your notes are stored only in this browser (localStorage) — use “*Export my notes*” to save them as a file before sharing the document.